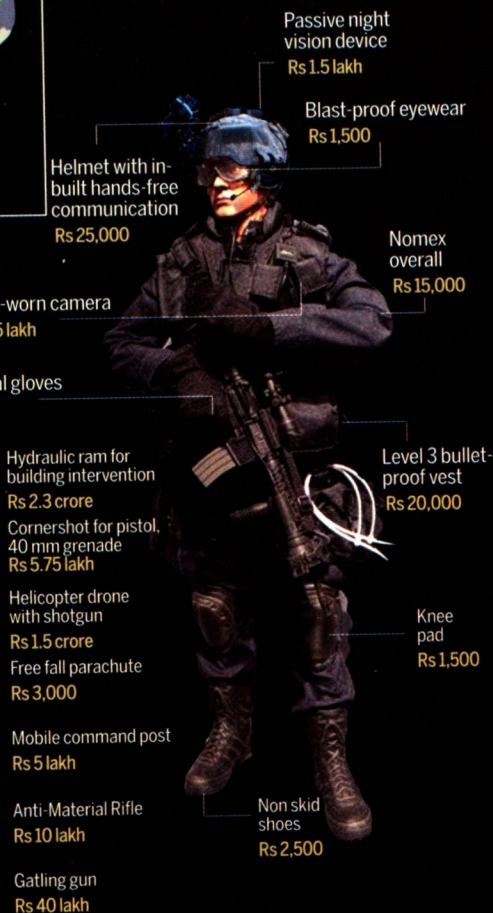


Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

WHAT THE NSG DOESN'T HAVE

Available off the shelf but never bought



MULTIPLIER TOTAL 1,406

Response Team of the Mumbai Police: 18
Commandos: 16 NSG: 200 Army Commandos: 65
Police: 1,000 SRPF guards: 100 RAF: 7 platoons

DEAD: 173 Injured: 288
In dead: 14 Foreigners dead: 26 Home Guard killed: 1
9 killed; 1 arrested

**NUMBER OF
S EVACUATED** The Taj: 345 The Oberoi: 450



**TWO OF THE BOMBS PLANTED
BY TERRORISTS EXPLODED IN
TAXIS IN VILE PARLE**

Vijay Salaskar and Additional Commissioner of Police Ashok Kamte in an ambush shows how ill-prepared the force is and the total absence of training, strategy or tactics through the crisis. Indeed Roy admits that "the response was very prompt but whether they were capable of neutralising terrorists is something that needs to be looked into". This admission, in a state racked by three serious terror attacks, tells the story of apathy. Within the hour when the two hotels and CST were targeted, it should have been clear that this was a major terrorist strike.

In theory, the crisis management group headed by the chief secretary and its members should have met within the hour. In Mumbai, the chief secretary was at home, the crisis room was manned by the DGP, Patil and senior officers and Home Secretary Chitkala Zutshi was among those trapped at the Sea Lounge in the Taj and calling for help. Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh was in Kerala and reached Mumbai only at 3 a.m. The state Government didn't lack advice. Last Monday Deshmukh announced the creation of a Maharashtra Security Council to advise the state. A similar council was also formed with army and police officials in September 2006 following the Mumbai serial blasts. Lieutenant General D.B. Shekatkar, a council member who has over 20 years of experience in "insurgency and terror" ops, reveals that the council has not met since August 2007. Worse, its suggestions—including one to strengthen coastal patrolling and involving the Koli community—were largely ignored.

This neglect clearly contributed to creating the landscape for the terrorists to strike at will. The desperate calls for help from Zutshi and other hostages in hotels should have prompted the state to call for the NSG. But it wasn't till midnight that the state asked for help from the Centre. Precious hours lost could have saved lives. When they did reach Mumbai at 6 a.m. on November 27, those watching television the world over were treated to the pathetic sight of them being transported in BEST buses.

The NSG itself did a good job but that they took 50 hours to clear the Taj raises questions.